

Republicans still waiting for a post-Labor Day recovery

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- *
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- *
How Republicans could win the House (even if it's not likely)
- *
Trump likely to avoid using US firepower in Yemen
- *
Record diesel prices will sharpen the affordability squeeze

This week in polling: Republicans still waiting for a post-Labor Day recovery. Democrats had a rosy week in polling of the key Senate races this week, continuing their small but meaningful leads in the toss-up states that will decide control of the chamber.

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In Maine, Democrat Troy Jackson led Senator Susan Collins (R-ME) by three and four points in CNN and YouGov polls respectively; Jackson hasn't trailed in a poll since early July, before he even formally became the Democratic nominee. It looks increasingly like Collins will need to pull a rabbit out of her hat—as she did in the 2020 cycle—to win this race.

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In Texas, Democrat James Talarico is still leading Republican Ken Paxton. The most worrying sign for Paxton was a Cook Political Report/TelevisaUnivision poll of Hispanics in the state, which found Talarico leading Paxton among the group by a stark 63-30, a striking shift from a group that exit polls found President Donald Trump won in 2024. If Paxton faces such a deficit among Hispanics, he'll need to limit his losses among suburban white voters to eke out a win in the state.

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North Carolina continues to look like a very likely Democratic pickup, with Democrat Roy Cooper leading Republican Michael Whately by a whopping eight and eleven points in two polls this week. The dominance of Cooper—a moderate, popular former governor—in the state means that national Democrats can forgo significant spending in this race, freeing up more dollars to go to what were once “reach” states, like Texas and Alaska.

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In some sense, these continued Democratic leads in individual races aren't surprising – President Trump's approval is still below 40%, and Democrats still retain a significant lead in the generic ballot. And with gas prices (and especially diesel prices) having picked up over the last week, the macro-political environment isn't shifting in favor of Republicans.

How Republicans could win the House (even if it's not likely). Eurasia Group sees Democrats as the strong favorites to win the House this year (85% odds), but it's not a sure thing; in 1 in 6 simulations of the world, Republicans maintain their majority. It's worth thinking about how this could happen, given the deficit that Republicans face in nationwide polling.

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The most plausible route to Republicans maintaining their majority would simply be favorable moves in the macro-political environment, potentially through de-escalation in the Middle East leading to a rapid drop in gas prices (which, given recent actions by the Houthis, is unlikely).

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In this context, it's important to remember that, thanks to a number of factors (including redistricting), Democrats will likely need to win the House popular vote by three or four points to win a House majority. A VoteHub analysis in June found the likely "tipping point" seat voted for Trump by 4.9 points in 2026, meaning Democrats would need roughly a +3.5-point national environment to win it.

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That means Republican's don't need a completely implausible 6.5-point shift in the generic ballot; they probably need more like a 2.5-to-3.5-point shift. That's very unlikely to occur—hence our view that Democrats are very likely to win the House—but it's not out of the realm of possibility.

Trump likely to avoid using US firepower in Yemen. The Houthis' seizure of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait in Yemen, increasing their ability to threaten Red Sea shipping, poses a new problem for the White House, mostly through its effect on global oil markets.

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Saudi Arabia has few military options to reverse Houthi advances – local partners in Yemen collapsed and show little willingness to fight, and direct Saudi attacks risk unacceptable collateral damage to static oil pipeline infrastructure, as laid bare by recent Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline. That means diplomatic efforts are the more likely path.

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It's unlikely Trump wants to get involved in what could become a military entanglement; his efforts against the Houthis early in his term sputtered, likely reducing his willingness to have another go.

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What is more likely is US support for Saudi-led diplomatic efforts, and potential operational support, such as intelligence-sharing and the sending of additional military advisors, for Saudi military efforts that may precipitate. But as President Trump's legacy is threatened by his sagging political approval ratings, Trump is unlikely to involve the US in direct military contact for fear it will enhance domestic perception that the Iran war has grown intractable.

Record diesel prices will sharpen the affordability squeeze. US retail diesel passed \$6 per gallon on Friday for the first time on record, up roughly 14% in a month and more than 60% year on year, as conflict-driven refining losses and a renewed crude rally push product prices to fresh highs.

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Diesel is a key cost in agricultural production, and trucking accounts for almost three-quarters of US goods transport, with price rises likely to be passed on to consumers over the coming months. A disproportionate impact on lower-income households widens the gap between the politics of affordability and the inflation measures the Fed targets: this morning's August CPI put headline at 3.4% year on year against core of 2.4%, with gasoline alone accounting for more than a third of the monthly increase and fuel oil up 52%.

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The binding constraint has shifted from crude availability to refining capacity. In April, restrictions on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz drove the immediate availability of oil. Product prices now reflect refinery damage in the Gulf and in Russia, compounded by Moscow's ban on diesel exports through 30 September. Distillate crack spreads have hit a record above \$100 per barrel and US distillate stocks sit 14% below their five-year average (see: Crude prices will exceed \$100 as the Middle East conflict drags on , 8 September 2026).

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The global shortage of refining capacity risks amplifying the economic impact of El Niño, with the countries most exposed to adverse weather effects on crop yields also highly dependent on diesel imports.

Quote of the Day

"The mindless slaughter of so many innocent civilians is an unacceptable act of violence without precedent in the modern era. It underscores the urgency of intensifying the battle against terrorism, a battle that the NATO countries - indeed all civilised nations - must win. All Allies stand united in their determination to combat this scourge." - Statement by NATO's North Atlantic Council on September 11, 2001.

On the Radar

10 August – 14 September: Senate on recess

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

3 November: National midterm elections

11 December: Government funding runs out

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